



Ajai Chowdhry with Prime Minister Narendra Modi

out a way. They used to request their pen friends abroad to stick a blade in every reply letter. Thus, they would have a fantastic Schick or Gillette blade with every letter.

Ajai's passion for sports continued during his college days. He mentions, "From table tennis I graduated to learning tennis, because my father was a tennis player. I also learned how to play badminton. I was always a racket player. Later, when I went to Singapore, I learned squash."

Ajai shared another interesting hobby with his college friend Suresh Sundaram. They were shortwave listeners (SWLs). They used to locate shortwave locations of many countries through their radios. It was like finding the frequencies of those radio stations and tuning the radio accordingly. Ajai also recalls spending hours with friends after college in his garden and listening to music together. Music remains an impor-

tant part of his life.

Cinema was another strong common bond between Ajai and his friends. He recalls, "We all used to go off to watch movies' night shows without informing our parents. We used to watch both Hindi and English movies, sitting next to the screen as it was difficult to afford costly back-row tickets. We used to look up to the great actor Dev Anand and I was very fond of him. We watched all his movies. I still remember my excitement after seeing the full-page advertisement for his great movie *Guide* in a newspaper named *Screen*. It was 1966 and I was in the final grade of my school. I used to keep waiting for the release of his movies to watch on the first day." His passion for

Dev Anand's movies continues as he did not miss even the last movie of that great actor.

Beginning of the professional life

Soon after completing his engineering degree in 1971, Ajai began his professional journey. He broke the then stereotype of 'getting into an engineering job in a government department.' While describing the same, he mentions, "My parents were always interested in all of their children getting into civil service, but none of us got into IAS." Ajai's elder brother joined an oil company. His suggestions influenced Ajai to

develop an interest in sales and marketing. Thus, he decided to take a job in sales and marketing engineering products.

Ajai began his career with Delhi Cloth & General Mills (DCM) Data Products as a sales trainee in the electronics product division of the company with a salary of ₹600 per month. After training, Ajai was posted in Mumbai for selling industrial-grade calculators. Ajai describes, "The office was in Churchgate area. It was on the mezzanine floor of a textiles shop. We had a little cubby hole-type office upstairs, where only five-six people could sit."

In Mumbai, Ajai shared a rented apartment in Ghatkopar with his manager Yogesh Vaidya. He recalls, "Oh, what a terrible place it was! The windowpanes were all broken. There was bird-shit all over the place. The only consolation was that there was a Udupi restaurant below. So, at least we had the option of breakfast. Soon we moved to an apartment near Juhu. Yogesh was married, so he got the bigger room and I got the little one. It was a nice arrangement because his wife was a good cook. I used to get home-cooked food. We commuted from Ghatkopar to Churchgate by bus or train."

While working at DCM, Ajai learned unique selling techniques from Yogesh and successfully handled many deals with clients like engineers in the state irrigation departments, chemists in the cooperative-run sugar factories in the rural areas of Maharashtra, etc. While describing his struggle in those early days, Ajai mentions that after completing the deals he used to befriend truck drivers to get back

"We all came to Delhi to attend a DCM conference. After that, we were invited by Shiv Nadar to his home. He told us that he was going to start a new business with Arjun Malhotra. He asked interested people to join his business. Initially, ten to twelve people were interested and I was one of them. However, after assessing the risk, only four dedicated people, including me, joined them. I was too young then, so I had nothing to lose. We decided to start our own computer business with the name Hindustan Computers Limited (HCL)."